MS WORD · STRUCTURE · STYLE

How to Write a Research Manuscript

Introduction · Methodology (STROBE) · Results · Discussion
Fill-in-the-blank templates · Verb tense guide · Professional formatting

A practical 10-slide guide for early-career researchers

What you will master today

01

Introduction architecture

5-paragraph model: Rationale → Global relevance → Problematization → Gap → Objectives

02

Methodology with STROBE

22-item checklist for observational studies + ready templates

03

Results writing

Background → Main findings → Supporting data (past tense)

04

Discussion craft

Key findings → Interpretation → Compare & contrast → Implications

05

Tenses & MS Word polish

Which tense where + professional formatting checklist

The 5-Paragraph Introduction Model

1. Rationale

Why this topic matters scientifically. Establish the broader context and importance of the research area.

2. Global / Area Relevance

Situate the problem in regional, national or global context. Show real-world significance and burden.

3. Problematization

Define the specific problem clearly. What is broken, incomplete or poorly understood?

4. Research Gap

What is missing in existing literature? Cite 2–4 key studies and show the unfilled space.

5. Motivation & Objectives

State why you conducted this study and list clear, measurable objectives / hypotheses.

Fill-in-the-blank starters · Present / Present Perfect

RATIONALE

_____ is a major public-health / scientific challenge because _____.

GLOBAL RELEVANCE

Worldwide, approximately _____ people are affected by _____, with the highest burden in _____.

PROBLEMATIZATION

Despite advances in _____, clinicians / researchers still face _____ when _____.

RESEARCH GAP

Previous studies have examined _____ (Author et al., Year); however, little is known about _____.

OBJECTIVES

Therefore, the present study aimed to (1) _____, (2) _____, and (3) _____.

TENSE GUIDE

Introduction

- Present tense for established facts
- Present perfect for previous research
- Past tense only when describing a specific past study's methods/results

Example

"Diabetes remains a leading cause of morbidity. Several studies have reported rising prevalence in South Asia."

STROBE: Strengthening the Reporting of Observational Studies

22-item checklist for cohort, case-control & cross-sectional studies (EQUATOR Network)

4

Study design

Present key elements early

5

Setting

Locations, dates, recruitment periods

6

Participants

Eligibility, sources, selection methods

7

Variables

Outcomes, exposures, confounders

8

Data sources

Measurement methods & comparability

9

Bias

Efforts to address potential sources

10

Study size

How sample size was determined

12

Statistical methods

All analyses, missing data, sensitivity

Ready-to-use sentences · Past tense throughout

STUDY DESIGN & SETTING

This _____ (cross-sectional / cohort / case-control) study was conducted at _____ between _____ and _____. Ethical approval was obtained from _____ (Ref. No. _____).

PARTICIPANTS

Eligible participants were _____ aged _____ years who _____. Exclusion criteria included _____. A total of _____ participants were enrolled using _____ sampling.

DATA COLLECTION & VARIABLES

Data were collected using a structured _____ administered by _____. The primary outcome was defined as _____. Potential confounders included _____.

STATISTICAL ANALYSIS

Continuous variables were summarized as mean ± SD or median (IQR). Associations were examined using _____ regression. A p-value < 0.05 was considered statistically significant. Analyses were performed in _____ (version _____).

From background to main findings

1. Participant flow

- Start with sample size & response rate
- Describe exclusions step-by-step
- Present baseline characteristics table
- Use past tense exclusively

2. Main results

- Lead with the primary outcome
- Report effect sizes + 95% CI
- Avoid interpreting (save for Discussion)
- Refer to figures/tables explicitly

3. Secondary / sensitivity

- Present secondary outcomes clearly
- Report subgroup or sensitivity analyses
- Note any missing-data handling
- Keep language neutral & factual

Fill-in-the-blank sentences · Past tense only

Participant characteristics

Of the _____ individuals screened, _____ (___%) met eligibility criteria and were included in the final analysis. The mean age was _____ ± _____ years; _____% were female.

Primary outcome

The prevalence / incidence of _____ was _____% (95% CI _____–_____). Compared with _____, the adjusted odds / risk ratio was _____ (95% CI _____–_____; p = _____).

Secondary findings

In subgroup analyses, the association remained significant among _____ (OR _____, 95% CI _____). Sensitivity analysis excluding _____ yielded similar results.

Table / Figure call-out

Baseline characteristics are presented in Table 1. Figure 2 illustrates the dose–response relationship between _____ and _____.

Key findings → Interpretation → Compare & contrast

01

Key findings

Restate the main results in plain language (1–2 sentences). Do not simply repeat numbers.

02

Interpretation

Explain what the findings mean. Link to biological, clinical or social mechanisms where possible.

03

Compare & contrast

Place your results next to 3–5 previous studies. Highlight agreements, differences and possible reasons.

04

Strengths, limits & implications

Honestly discuss limitations. End with concrete implications for practice, policy or future research.

Templates + MS Word professional polish

DISCUSSION STARTERS

1. In this _____ study of _____ participants, we found that _____.

2. Our findings are consistent with those of _____ et al., who reported _____.

3. In contrast to _____ (Year), we observed a weaker / stronger association, possibly due to _____.

4. Several limitations should be acknowledged. First, _____. Second, _____.

5. These results have important implications for _____ and suggest that future research should _____.

MS WORD CHECKLIST

- ✓ Font: Times New Roman or Georgia 12 pt body
- ✓ Line spacing: 1.5 or double
- ✓ Margins: ≥ 2.5 cm all sides
- ✓ Page numbers bottom centre
- ✓ Consistent heading styles (Heading 1/2)
- ✓ Tables: editable, not images
- ✓ Citations: EndNote / Zotero / Mendeley
- ✓ Spell-check + grammar (UK/US consistent)
- ✓ STROBE checklist attached if observational
- ✓ Word count within journal limit